

Every experiment has strengths and weaknesses. Some are quick and cheap but produce less reliable evidence. Some produce more reliable evidence but require more time and money to execute.

Consider your journey, risk category, resources and strength of evidence required when you choose an experiment. As a rule of thumb, start cheap when uncertainty is high and increase your spending on experiments with increasing certainty.

Here are just a few of many experiments. Click on each to learn more.

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Experiments Library



Link Tracking

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Setup unique link tracking to verify potential customers' or partners' interest beyond what they might tell you in a meeting, interview, or call. It's an extremely simple way to measure genuine interest.

1. **"Fabricate" a unique link.** Make a unique and trackable link to more detailed information about your ideas (e.g. a download, landing page) with a service such as [bitly](#).
2. **Pitch and track.** Explain your idea to a potential customer or partner. During or after the meeting (via e-mail), give the person the unique link and mention it points to more detailed information.
3. **Learn about genuine interest.** Track if the customer used the link or not. If the link wasn't used, it may indicate lack of interest or more important jobs, pains, and gains than those that your idea addresses.



Customer Discovery Interviews

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Talk to customers to gain insights relevant to your context. Use the Value Proposition Canvas to prepare interviews and organize the chaotic mass of information that will be coming at you during the interview process.

1. **Create a customer profile.** Sketch out the jobs, pains, and gains you believe characterize the customer you are targeting. Rank jobs, pains, and gains in order of importance.
2. **Create an interview outline.** Ask yourself what you want to learn. Derive the interview questions from your customer profile. Ask about the most important jobs, pains, and gains. Download this [cheat sheet](#) for writing interview questions.
3. **Conduct the interview.** Conduct the interview by following the [interview ground rules](#).

4. **Capture.** Map out the jobs, pains, and gains you learned about in the interview on an empty customer profile. Make sure you also capture business model learnings. Write down your most important insights.
5. **Review the interview.** Assess if you need to review the interview questions based on what you learned.
6. Repeat steps 2-5
7. **Search for patterns.** Can you discover similar jobs, pains, and gains? What stands out? What is similar or different among interviewees? Why are they similar or different? Can you detect specific (recurring) contexts that influence jobs, pains, and gains?
8. **Synthesize.** Make a separate synthesized customer profile for every customer segment that emerges from all your interviews. Write down your most important insights on sticky notes.

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Mock Sales

A great way to test sincere customer interest is to setup a mock sale before your value proposition even exists. The goal is to make your customers believe they are completing a real purchase. This is easily done in an online context but can also be done in a physical one.



Online

- Test different levels of customer commitment with three different types of experiments:
 - Learn about customer interest by measuring how many people click on a simple "buy now" button.
 - Learn how pricing influences customer interest. Combine with A/B testing to learn more about demand elasticity and the optimal price point.
 - Get hard data by simulating a transaction with the customer's credit card information. This is the strongest evidence of customer demand.

Physical World

- Mock sales are not limited to online. Here's what retailers do to test customer interest and pricing in the real world:
 - Introduce products that don't exist yet in a limited number of (mail order) catalogs.
 - Sell a product in one retail location only for a limited amount of time.

Tips

- Don't fear that mock sales might alienate customers and negatively affect your brand. Manage customer perception well, and mock sales can be turned into an advantage. Build on these three best practices:
 - Explain that you were performing a test after the

customer completes the mock purchase.

- Be transparent about which information you keep or erase.
- Always erase credit card information in a fake purchase.
- Offer a reward for participating in the test (e.g. goodies, discounts).
- You will turn test subjects into advocates for your brand rather than alienate them if you manage customer perception well.



A/B Test

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A/B testing is a technique to compare the performance of two options. The most common form of A/B testing is to test two variations of a web page. This technique was popularized by companies such as Google and LinkedIn, as well as the 2008 Obama campaign. A/B tests can also be conducted in the physical world. The main learning instrument is to compare if conversion rates regarding a specific call-to-action differ between competing alternatives.

What to test?

Here are some elements you can easily test with A/B testing:

- Alternative features
- Pricing
- Discount
- Copy text
- Packaging
- Website variations

Call-to-action

As you design your A/B test, integrate a CTA and ask how many of the test subjects perform the CTA:

- Purchase
- E-mail sign-up
- Click on button
- Survey
- Completion of any task

Tips

- Test a single variation if you want to clearly identify what leads to a better performance.
- Use so-called multivariate testing to test several combined elements to figure out which combination creates the highest impact.
- Use Google AdWords or other options to attract test subjects.

- Make sure you reach a statistical significance of greater than 95%.
- Use tools such as Google Website Optimizer, Optimizely, or others to easily perform A/B test.



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Wizard of Oz

To run a "Wizard of Oz" MVP, set up a front stage that mimics a real, working value proposition. On the back-end you will manually carry out the tasks of what would normally be a more automated process for delivering your value proposition. This is great to learn if your solution actually exceeds a certain threshold before you automate and scale your solution more permanently.

Prepare

- Plan the steps of creating the product manually.
- Test the steps with someone internally first to make sure it works.
- Integrate and verify web analytics are working correctly (if required).

Execute

- Find users for the Wizard of Oz experiment.
- Conduct the experiment.
- Document how long it took to complete each of the tasks.
- Gather feedback from the users with interviews and surveys.

Analyze

- Review your customer satisfaction feedback.
- Review your metrics for:
 - Length of time for each task
 - Where you experienced delays in the process
 - How many purchased or interacted with CTA

Use these findings to improve on your next Wizard of Oz experiment and to help inform where to automate the process.

If you want to learn more about different types of experiments, we suggest you read [Testing Business Ideas](#), which includes a detailed library of 44 experiments.